THE SPACE RANGER



Susmita Mohanty, *52*
Director-General, Spaceport SARABHAI

AS THE HEAD AND CO-FOUNDER of Spaceport SARABHAI, or S2, India's first and only 'space' think tank, Susmita Mohanty's sole mission since she first became an entrepreneur 22 years back has been to position her country as a global space power. Born in Cuttack and raised in Ahmedabad, Susmita, whose father Nilamani Mohanty was an ISRO scientist, is perhaps the only space entrepreneur today to have co-founded companies on three continents: EARTH2ORBIT in Bengaluru (2009-2021), LIQUIFER Systems Group in Vienna (2004—), and MOONFRONT in San Francisco (2001-2007).

Through EARTH-2ORBIT, Susmita played a pivotal role in enabling the first-ever launch agreement between the American Skybox and India's Antrix. That half-a-decade-long 'technology diplomacy' paved the way for many more American satellites to be launched on the Indian PSLV rocket. "With technology diplomacy, we made history despite the remnants of the 1988 US sanctions against India. In 2014, Skybox became the first US company to sign a launch agreement with Antrix. And, in 2017, when the PSLV broke the world record by launching 104 satellites on a single rocket, 96 of them were American ones," she says.

But that journey hasn't without challenges—like bureaucracy, raising funds, and navigating export and regulatory hurdles. Before starting her own businesses, Susmita had worked on Shuttle-Mir missions at the NASA Johnson Space Centre in Houston, and later was part of the International Space Station (ISS) programme at Boeing in Huntington Beach. The latter, she says, was a turning point. "I worked in international business development for the ISS programme. I was part of a small team responsible for bid and proposal, negotiations and management of global contracts. That experience, along with my training in engineering and industrial design, gave me the skills to launch my own companies," says Susmita.

ACCOMPLISHMENT

A spaceship designer, entrepreneur and space diplomat rolled into one, Susmita Mohanty has been pushing the boundaries of space research for over two decades now

Institutions the world over seek her expertise. The Swiss Space Office invited her for inputs for the 2023 Swiss Space Policy, she is is a member of the World Economic Forum Global Future Council for Space Technologies, a non-resident scholar at Carnegie India, and serves on the advisory boards of the global alliance for Earth-Space Governance and the space centre at École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne, Switzerland. In 2012, Susmita was on the *Financial Times*' list of '25 Indians to Watch'; two years later, she graced the cover of *Fortune* magazine and, in 2019, she was featured by the BBC among 100 women shaping a female-led future. On India's 75th anniversary of Independence, Susmita was among the 75 women honoured with the Women Transforming India awards. The sky, though, is not her limit. She also marks her presence in the arts space, with MAD Salon+Lab, an institution focused on art, architecture and contemporary culture that she runs along with her husband. ■

-Amarnath K. Menon

OWN YOUR SPACE

"Have a sense of purpose and a vision for the future"

PRE-SCIENCE At the age of 29, when Susmita decided to leave her job and become an entrepreneur, her boss told her, "starting one's own company is like having quintuplets". "In retrospect", she says, "it was spot-on"